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‘Pavements at TTK Road not easy on the feet’

RAMDAS NAIK

The pavements on TTK Road, from Music Academy up to the Alwarpet flyover signal, need to be relaid and made pedestrian-friendly. Currently, these pavements resemble an obstacle course; one encounters a similar situation at CIT Colony. Ramdas Naik is secretary CIT RWA



‘Address two issues at Infinity Park in Santhome’

BASKAR SESHADRI

Infinity Park in Santhome is getting greater footfall in recent days, particularly in the last one week or so, due to schools closing for festivals.

But those visiting the park are up against two challenges. One, parking of vehicles in front of the

park disturbs children as also the senior citizens who bring them to the park. The entry to the park is blocked by a row of cars.

Two, some grown-up visitors at the park head there in the evening to have a game of the sports they fancy.

The park is primarily

meant for children, and adults can be around but without preventing them from making optimal use of the facilities. The park attendant has reminded the grownups about this many a time, but the cautionary word falls on deaf ears.

Baskar Seshadri is a resident of Mylapore

A skill that bloomed afresh during the *pandemic*

From origami classes at Rosary matriculation school to the two-day Makers Market in Mylapore now, resident Priya Subramaniam has come a long way. She would be showcasing her paper flowers at the event, which concludes today

The pandemic has been an inflexion point for many, giving them the mental space to revive old passions, sometimes dusting off an old hobby or rejuvenating an old skill that had all but atrophied.

Priya Subramaniam can relate to that. For her, a fascination for paper crafts began with an exposure to origami at school, Rosary Matriculation School in Santhome. She was sold on the idea of creating snowflakes and flowers with nothing but paper.

She would turn her hand at paper quilling and paper cutting, but that was about it, the interest and aptitude were stunted, not reaching its potential, until the pandemic happened, when it bloomed afresh and big. It has only gotten bigger since then.

“The pandemic happened and I chanced upon the world of paper flowers. These were more realistic and lifelike than the ones I had made before. I came across Youtube videos and started attempting them. It took me a while to learn different techniques of colouring paper, stretching and



moulding it to resemble real petals. Books on paper flower making and online video tutorials helped refine my process,” says Priya.

The pandemic had a markedly clear silver lining for her; paper flower making would soon graduate from being an interest and hobby horse into an enterprise.

She has discovered a hugely responsive marketplace in Instagram.

“Instagram has opened me to a world of amazing artists and helps put my work out there and get feedback and appreciation,” she elaborates.

Exhibitions

In the online world, artists are not constrained by geography, their works being transported to the nooks



and crannies of the world, but still, there is a majesty about displaying one’s works in a physical space for eyes to see and appreciate. Priya wanted that experience for her, and that came her way.

“Fuelled by positive response to my posts on Instagram, I participated in an event by Flair street events,



showing my work along with other artists,” says Priya.

And she in the midst of another opportunity. Paper flowers made by her are at display at Makers Market

(March 22 is the concluding day) in Mylapore, organised by “By Hand From The Heart”.

Priya’s Insta handle is @paperflowersbypriya

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A 'JAMMING' SESSION AHEAD OF TN ELECTIONS

A data jam on March 28 will have participants studying how the Assembly constituencies in and around Chennai are faring on a set of parameters **P2**



SILENT READING SHIFTS TO NEW PARK

From Nageswara Rao park, closed for renovation, the initiative has shifted to a green space in RK Nagar, where it seems to have discovered a new home **P4**

'Halt more buses at this point on NSC Bose Road'

Currently, only the services in the 32 series stop on the section of the road adjacent to the temporarily closed terminus

R. RAGU

On NSC Bose Road in George Town, by the side of the bus terminus, which is barricaded with blue metal sheets for reconstruction work, buses in the 32-series halt. This provision is proving to be a boon to those visiting various categories of shops in the Parrys market to buy goods for their home and personal needs or for retailing in other parts of Chennai.

Arul Kumar, in charge of the Harbour section of Chennainagara Sirukadaigal Vyaparigal Sangam

(which translates to "Association for Small Traders in Chennai City") expresses the collective wish of the traders community in Parrys that other bus services from other parts of the city also halt around this section. To this effect, the Sangam has made a plea to MTC.

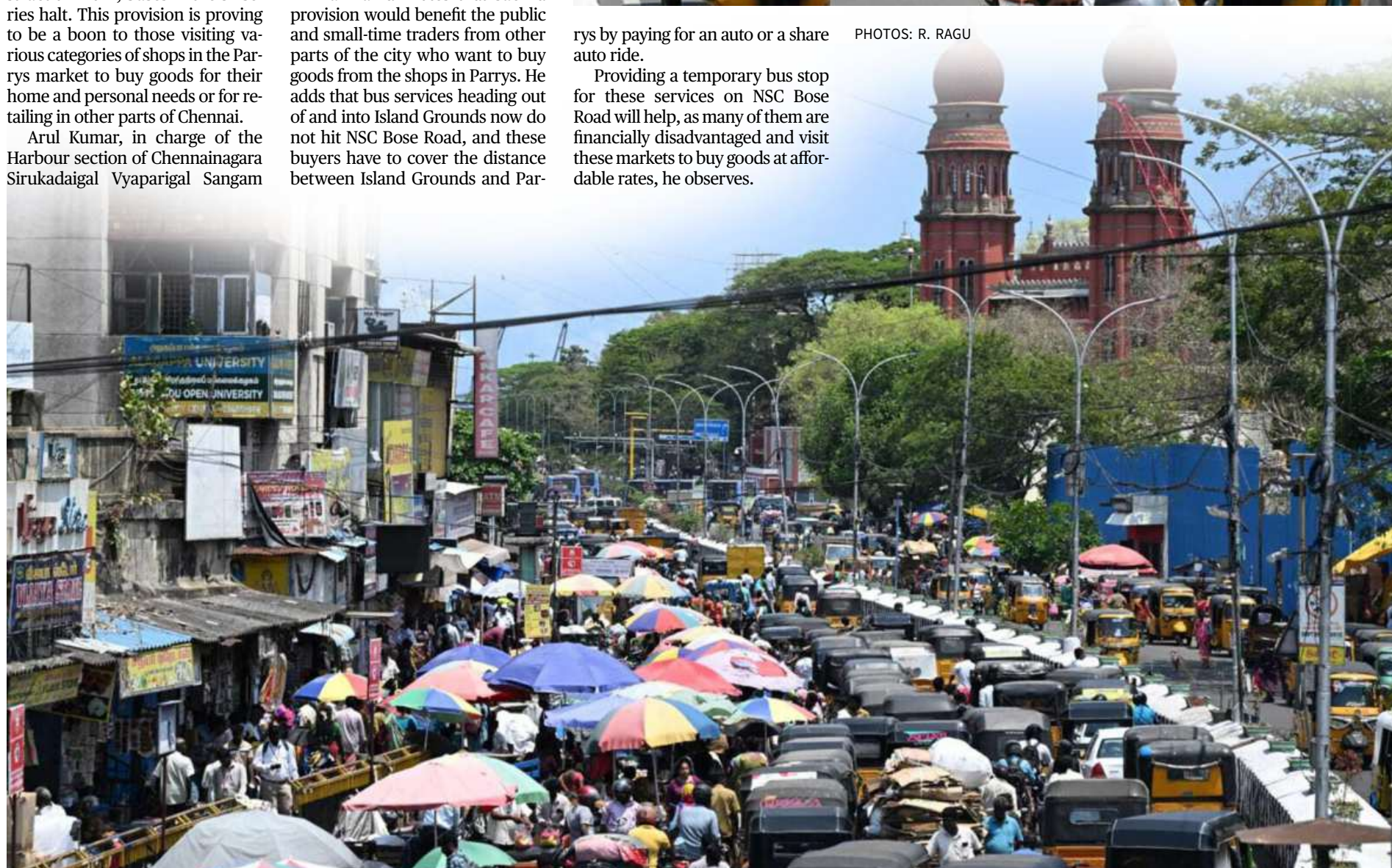
Arul Kumar notes that such a provision would benefit the public and small-time traders from other parts of the city who want to buy goods from the shops in Parrys. He adds that bus services heading out of and into Island Grounds now do not hit NSC Bose Road, and these buyers have to cover the distance between Island Grounds and Par-



rys by paying for an auto or a share auto ride.

PHOTOS: R. RAGU

Providing a temporary bus stop for these services on NSC Bose Road will help, as many of them are financially disadvantaged and visit these markets to buy goods at affordable rates, he observes.



A data jam on March 28 will have participants studying how the Assembly constituencies in and around Chennai are faring on a set of parameters

LIFFY THOMAS

If data is a key factor for you to assess your constituency's performance then this event is for you. OpenCity, a civic tech platform that makes data easy to find, access, share and analyse is hosting a data jam on March 28 at Bhumi in Alwarpet to gauge how the city fared in parameters such as health, education, public transport, civic engagement and performance of the MLAs in the 20 Assembly constituencies in and around Chennai.

Data jam is not new to Chennai. OpenCity (a programme of the Oorvani Foundation) has in the past conducted similar workshops to study urban heat, lakes and flooding, and this one is planned to give participants a better understanding of the performance of the different constituencies ahead of the Assembly elections.

Here people from diverse professional backgrounds work in groups to understand how data can be used to understand civic issues plaguing the city.

Data available in the public domain is shared with participants and they analyse, brainstorm to get a better understanding of the issues and also give solutions.

For example, data from different databases and portals such as www.dge.tn.gov.in and UDISE will be used to get information on the number of government schools in an area, students enrolled and the count of teachers.

"Participants correlate to find what is lacking in every constituency," says Vaidya R., programme lead, Oorvani Foundation.

In 2024, the organisers used satellite data to understand ur-



A 'jamming' session ahead of TN elections

ban heat in different localities of Chennai. For instance, Koyamedu Metro was one of the hottest spots. In the part of Chennai it is located, Perungudi dumping ground topped the charts for extremely hot conditions.

The significance

"Either through maps put out by Greater Chennai Corporation or through their own experiences, participants correlated urban heat area," says Vaidya.

In some of the data jams, stakeholders take part in them or the findings are shared with them. The data jam on urban heat was presented to CMDA.

"A stakeholder could be a civic group working on the ground, and they could include the findings in petitions they submit to government departments," says Vaidya.

OpenCity has conducted data jams in all major metros and is happy these events offer people a platform to share their experiences. In Bangalore, a participant went on to develop a tool to measure the "public transport affinity" for a given area.

The data jam is being conducted in partnership with Citizen Consumer and Civic Action Group, Reach the Unreached and Nagariyal. For details, visit <https://forms.gle/cUIdseNvY-Yx4PWL78> or scan the QR code



'Data is a weapon'

Tambaram resident Raju K, working with a research agency, uses data to take up issues he feels strong about. In his mid-20s, Raju attended a data jam on lakes conducted by OpenCity; since then, he has been hugely curious about data jams.

A volunteer with Chennai Wetlands Action Collective and Save Madambakkam Lake Committee, Raju says OpenCity is a one-stop place to find data about a number of things.

For instance, for Save Madambakkam Lake Committee, they were able to get different data in the portal and use it in GIS maps and observe what the violations were.

"The data about the elevation of residential area, the lake and the real estate development next to the lake helped us get the real picture and petition various government authorities and seek action. We also found that as due to the difference in height, surface run-off water could not enter the lake and would inundate the existing residential area," he says.

Another example of using data is to analyse why certain areas get more inundated. "We studied 2015 inundation map and an earlier one to analyse Porur lake's catchment area. Urbanisation and SWDs not being interconnected were among reasons why inundation was common in this belt," he says.

Art exhibition at Cathedral Road

The three-day exhibition happening at Kalpa Druma concludes on March 23

Thooriga, a collective of four women artists, is having its seventh art exhibition till March 23 at Kalpa Druma, Cathedral Road, Gopalapuram.

Each exhibition of Thooriga celebrates Tamil Nadu's rich cultural heritage, the beauty of nature, and the strength and grace of women in art.

In its previous editions, Thooriga has captivated audiences through a unique blend of individual creativity and collaborative spirit, said a release. The show will feature artworks by Gayathri Balaji, Yamuna Bala, Sathya N. Prabhu, and Charanya Rajesh. They explore themes that connect tradition, spirituality, storytelling, and the inner strength of human experience.

Charanya Rajesh's works celebrate the spiritual symbolism of



women, drawing inspiration from Indian scriptures and portraying the beauty, courage, and compassion of women. Sathya N. Prabhu's artworks invite viewers into a reflective journey that bridges past and present, creating emotional connections through artistic expression. Gayathri Balaji's paintings draw deeply from epic narratives, portraying vivid moments through traditional artistic tech-

niques. Yamuna Bala's works explore the immense inner strength, resilience, and potential within every human being.

The event is supported by the Department of Art and Culture, Government of Tamil Nadu, which provides sponsorships to promote artists through group and solo exhibitions, added the release. The initiative was announced in January 2026.



▼ The group and some of their artworks.

Valedictory ceremony at Stella Maris College



▼ At the event.

Stella Maris College hosted its ceremonial and traditional valedictory ceremony on March 18, marking the end of the academic journey of its final-year students. The programme began with a traditional lighting of the lamp, followed by a multi-faith prayer service with readings from the Holy Bible, Gitanjali, and the holy Quran, reflecting the institution's inclusive ethos, said a release. The western music club of the college rendered hymns that set a solemn tone for the evening.

The event was graced by chief guest Ramya Kannan, Health Editor and Chief of Bureau, *The Hindu*, Tamil Nadu, and an alumna of the college. Principal Sr. Stella Mary, and secretary Sr. Judith Anita Gonsalvaz felicitated the chief guest with a memento and a flower pot. In her address, Ramya Kannan motivated and inspired the students with her reflections on the impor-

tance of women to take care of themselves, personal grit and resilience, and heightened social responsibility. She added "Every monsoon we fall down and every monsoon we rise back," thereby encouraging the students to be bold achievers who persevere through challenges.

Nalini Raj, coordinator of The Alumnae Association of Stella Maris College (AASMC) presented the annual report, which was followed by a video showcasing the alumnae association activities and initiatives over the years. The annual newsletter of AASMC was unveiled by the principal, and the other dignitaries, marking another milestone and the institution's ongoing engagement with alumni.

Students from various departments shared their reflections on their academic journey highlighting growth, friendship, and learning experiences at the college.

A splash with colours



▼ Artworks created by 120 students are displayed at Kalaa Manjari Creativity Center – Global Art in Alwarpet. The annual art exhibition 'Hi Buddy 2026' showcases the creativity, imagination, and dedication to art. Families, friends, and art enthusiasts are invited to view the display that is open till today. Visitors can also participate by casting their offline and online votes for their favourite artworks. Kalaa Manjari is at 2nd street, East Abhiramapuram, Alwarpet, behind Nageswara Rao Park.

Silent reading shifts to a new park

From Nageswara Rao park, which is closed for renovation, this initiative has shifted to a green space in RK Nagar, where it seems to have discovered a new home



PRINCE FREDERICK

Balaji Silent Reader @park. That is a digital contact card, an eyebrow-raising one clearly. It raised this writer's eyebrows when it popped up on his WhatsApp screen. It had been shared by K.L. Balasubramanian, a social entrepreneur driving RK Nagarra community developments, RK Nagarra being an association of residents groups in and around RK Nagar, the last outpost of Greater Chennai Corporation's Zone 13. KL Balasubramanian had reasons to save this contact this way.

It is obvious the number behind the card belongs to one Balaji, and as it appears, he is someone who knows how to keep his jaws locked while his eyes are scanning the pages of a book, and displays this behaviour at a park. What is not obvious is that he, Balaji Venkataraman, a resident of D'Silva Road in Mylapore, makes sure jaws not his own are also locked and that the nose above those jaws are buried in a book. He is the face of the silent



reading movement in these parts.

The silent reading movement in the Mylapore-Mandaveli-RA Puram area showed up first at Nageswara Rao Park around two years ago, with modest ambitions, when Balaji launched it along with other reading enthusiasts from the region. Before heading back into the genesis

account, an update.

New space

This initiative has moved parks, and seems to set to get entrenched in one. Due to renovation work at Nageswara Park, the reading session became irregular. With the Nageswara Rao park work gaining



▼
Snapshots of a silent reading session.

turned up."

Back to the genesis story at Nageswara Rao Park, participants' numbers swelled, the needle being pushed by two hands, curiosity and engagement.

Curiosity drew some feet, which stayed put when the value of what was being imparted to participants stood out. K.R. Jambunathan, a resident of Kallukaran Street in Mylapore, is one such active participant.

Balaji notes that the exercise is aimed at people across age groups and though it has achieved this objective, children and senior citizens are a dominant presence at these Sunday sessions. Volunteers ensure books are at hand, the hat having been passed around to buy books; pre-read books make it to the collection as donation.

Though the one-hour, Sunday evening session is pledged to silence, it has to be broken for two reasons, one storytelling, handled by Bhavana; and two, snacks time. Volunteers pool in money to buy snacks for participants. Sometimes, snacks arrive from morem-lagai.com, a catering service in Mylapore, promoted by Viji Ganesh.

(The silent reading session on March 22 is from 4 p.m. onwards at the park next to Ragamalika in RK Nagar.)

more surface area, it had to be shifted elsewhere. "On the Sunday of March 8, 2026 it went to a park at De Monte Colony on the suggestion of Vincent D'Souza, editor and publisher of *Mylapore Times*. And on March 15, it went to a park in RK Nagar, the one next to Ragamalika Apartments. And this Sunday (March 22), it will take place again at this park in RK Nagar," says Balaji.

And it seems set to continue with the newly discovered green patch in RK Nagar in the Sundays to follow.

Balaji observes, "The response last week at the park in RK Nagar was great; around 30 people



Calcutta, I'm Sorry wants to be on OTT

Global Anglo-Indian Network (GAIN) has started a petition to help take Chennai resident Harry MacLure's latest film to a global audience

LIFFY THOMAS

Chennai-based Harry MacLure, a well-known face of the Anglo-Indian community, is drumming up support for the release of his latest film *Calcutta, I'm Sorry* on OTT platforms.

Global Anglo-Indian Network (GAIN) has started a petition on Change.org asking people to support the campaign and showcase the talented, spirited people who have been part of the film.

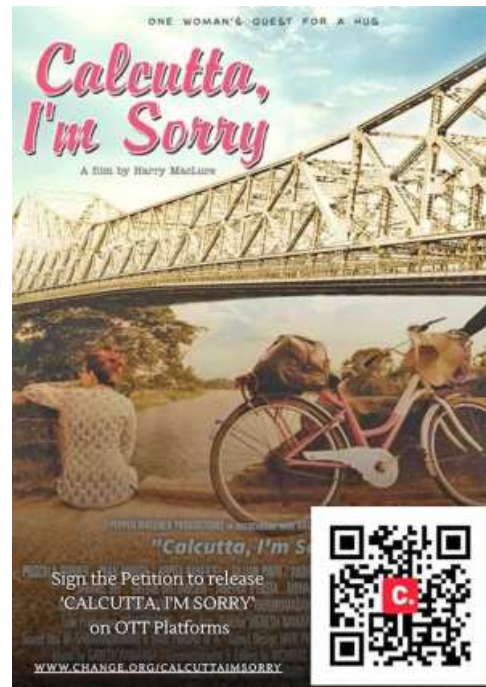
Harry, who has scripted and directed the film, is a board member of GAIN. *Calcutta, I'm Sorry* is centred around Anglo-Indian characters, but is not a story about the Anglo-Indian community *per se* but

brings out the essence of being Anglo-Indian. Featuring Priscilla Corner, who plays the protagonist Amanda Wright diagnosed with multiple sclerosis, the film takes viewers on an emotional road trip from Coonoor to Kolkata on a trusty bicycle to to meet her granddaughter.

The work on the movie began in 2019, but pandemic and other challenges delayed its theatrical release. In 2022, Harry and team completed the post production of the film that runs to one hour and 52 minutes.

"Usually a movie is released in theatres and then someone comes forward to buy it and put it on an OTT platform, which did not happen in the case of this film," says Harry, who has started the petition to get more signatures so that it draws the attention of OTT platforms.

Besides showcasing the artistic talent of the Anglo-Indian community, the film has a powerful



The film takes viewers on an emotional road trip from Coonoor to Kolkata on a bicycle.

message from a lady with multiple sclerosis.

The petition reads, "This film beautifully captures the essence of our journey, moving through themes of family, search and redemption as it follows a determined woman's journey on a bicycle. It is a story of a woman's quest for a hug from a granddaughter she has never met, representing the deep emotional roots and resilience of our people."

By supporting this campaign, you are helping us amplify voices that have remained on the periphery for too long, the note adds.

Special screening

In the last few years, Harry has been screening the film for select groups. The Multiple Sclerosis So-

ciety of India, Chennai chapter, had a special screening of the film in 2024.

Recently, a Malayalam film distributor who liked the film said the movie would do well in Malayalam and wanted Harry to dub it.

"But I am hesitant, how can an Anglo-Indian story where we speak in English do well in Malayalam?" he wonders.

Filmmaking is not new to Harry who also is editor of *Anglos In The Wind*, a magazine for the community. In 2013, he directed *Going Away*, a film about the community's migration to foreign lands.

The petition adds: "Help us showcase the talented bunch we are and ensure the world truly knows us through our films."

Visit <https://c.org/CSwSdX7Djv>.

A platform for individuals with special needs

The inaugural edition of Kalarangam, a stage for performing arts, for individuals with special needs, was held at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan in Mylapore. Initiated by the Vocational Training Unit (VTU) Sreyes, a joint undertaking of V-Excel Educational Trust and ESVI Sarada Foundation, the event was a platform for divyang artists and students of the Tamilnadu J Jayalalitha Music and Fine Arts University.

Vocalist Samaya Ishwarya and mridangist Pranav Ramesh, with support from Mangalam on the violin, provided an afternoon of pleasing and enjoyable music. The music transcended challenges and brought out the artists in them, said a release.

The event was graced by Dr. S. Radhakrishnan, Additional Chief Secretary,



From the event.

Government of Tamil Nadu; renowned mridangam maestro Sangeetha Kalanidhi Thiruvavur Bakthavathsalam, Carnatic vocalist Kalaimamani Srimathi Nithyasree Mahadevan; and K. Venkitachalam, Deputy Director of Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan.

Advocate and theatre artist Dharma Raman, who was present for the occasion, commended the performing artists for their dedication and expressive presentation.

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A grand festival

M. SRINATH

Devotees recently thronged Sri Vedanta Desikar Devasthanam in Mylapore for a special festival. The Poorvaanga Poojas began from the evening of the March 12. On that day, from 7 pm onwards, prayers to the Bhagavad

Prarthana, Anugnyai, Punyavachanam, Aasthu Shanthi Homam were conducted. On the eve of samprokshanam, 108 Kalasa Special Thirumanjanam were performed. Punyahavasnam and Vastu Shanti Homam were held.

On March 16, from 9.15 am to 10.30 am, Maha Samprokshanam was held. Following that, the



Acharyadhis performed their Bahu Manams. At 7 pm, the Thiruveedi Purappadu of Sri Perumal, Desikan and the special procession was held.

According to historical accounts, Sri Vedanta Desikar Devasthanam in Mylapore is said to have originated four centuries ago. In 1832, the idols of Sri Vedanta Desikar and Hayak Grevar were installed by some devotees. In 1924, the idols of Srinivasa Perumal and Alarmel Mangai Thayar were installed in the same shrine.

Teachers raise demands at meet

Members of School Voice -Tamil Nadu Private Schools Association wanted more private school teachers to be given Dr. Radhakrishnan Best Teachers Award

School Voice-Tamil Nadu Private Schools Association honoured about 710 teachers at the teachers' conference 'Right, Respect, Knowledge' organised in association with the YMCA Madras on March 7.

Several teachers, school administrators and educationists from across the State took part in the event organised to commemorate International Women's Day. While 76 principals and administrators were conferred with the 'Global Torch' awards, 41 teachers received the 'Veera Aasiriyar-Vedarnam Suganthi Award-2026'.

Martin Kennedy, School Voice Presi-

dent, expressed gratitude to Chief Minister M.K.Stalin for releasing ₹ 870 crore towards pending Right to Education fee reimbursements to private schools.

Highlighting the resolutions passed during the conference, he said the State government must enact a Teachers and Educational Institutions Protection Act, on the lines of the Tamil Nadu Medicare Service Persons and Medicare Service Institutions (Prevention of Violence and Damage or Loss to Property) Act.

Noting that only 38 out of 400 Dr. Radhakrishnan Best Teachers Award

are allotted to private school teachers, Kennedy said the number of awards must be increased to 800, with 400 awards reserved for private school teachers.

The association's General Secretary M. J. John Arokia Prabhu said the State Council of Educational Research and Training should extend the skill development and incentive training programmes currently being provided to government school teachers to private school teachers as well.

G. Vanitha, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Crime against Women and Children), Parveen, Secretary, Women Lawyers Association, the association's women committee members, including Florence Durairaj, Baggyam Thangaraj, Dorathy Prema, Sugantha Bhai and Soundary Grace also spoke.

Spot the planets today

Science and Nature Club of Periyar Nagar, is organising 'We shall measure the sky', a naked eye astronomy event on March 22 at 6.30 p.m.

Duraiswamy Navaneetham, who holds a doctorate in molecular biology, will take participants on a stargazing journey. They will be guided to locate Venus, Jupiter, stars and stellar constellations.

Entry is free. Interested people may call 9962565743. Details of the venue will be shared through WhatsApp.

Reflexology centre in Alwarpet

Happy Foot Reflexology at Alwarpet provides therapies to relieve stress, improve circulation, and ease tensions. Happy Foot is located on the second floor of a building numbered 32, TTK Road, Demonte Colony, Alwarpet.

The centre is open from 10 a.m. to 10 p.m., and can be contacted at 7200405144. Website: <https://happyfootspa.in/>

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